middle of NEFA which for purposes of this paper, I shall call the Defence Line.'

Frankly, this was not a plan that needed an army commander's input; it should have been obvious to any soldier with the slightest common sense. Unfortunately, the exact alignment of the Thorat Line was flawed as it was drawn off a map. In the Kameng Division, the Tawang-Bomdila axis was actually a line of withdrawal, ignoring Se-la as a possible defensive position. If maintaining the defensive line from the plains was to be the criterion, then the line ought to have run from the Manda-la Heights (the approach to Dirang Dzong running parallel to the Indo-Bhutan border) to Bomdila, which was thirty kilometres to its west. The other problem was that each anticipated point of entry of the enemy needed to be dealt with separately as there was no lateral communication between these points.

## THORAT'S DEFENSIVE LINE

In 2006, Major General D. K. Palit, accompanied by a bottle of Black Dog scotch whisky, visited us at home in Gurgaon. I had just got my hands on the Lal Qila file and was extremely keen to go over its contents with the general. Palit had been John Dalvi's predecessor, having commanded 7 Brigade and inducted it into NEFA. Apart from being one of the few officers at the time who had any idea of the ground realities of the Kameng Division, he was also familiar with the terrain extending up to Khenzemane. He had been Director, Military Operations (DMO) during the fateful period in 1962, and had also written a book, *War in the High Himalayas*, which critics rightly felt was aimed entirely at exonerating himself and the Military Operations Directorate in Army HQ that was under his charge.

'Thorat's so-called defensive line was completely at odds with what was being asked for by the government of India,' explained Palit. 'At the time, I too felt he was being a bit vague, and like Thimayya, was being a defeatist when it came to China. Thorat's defensive line did not cut ice with anyone because once the Chinese had chased away our border outposts they could easily halt at the second tier of defence having captured their main objective. It amounted to surrendering our territory without firing a single shot. It was politically unpalatable and no one in India was willing to lose even one square inch of ground.

'I was commanding 7 Brigade and was too junior to be invited to attend the Lal Qila Exercise, but my GOC (4 Division), Major General Amrik